The Shape of Things

By Neil LaBute

EVELYN: *(To audience)* Good evening. I promise to make this presentation as quick and painless as possible. My task tonight is to unveil my semester's work. . . Oh, I almost forgot . . . and this is fairly personal, so please indulge me. *(beat)* I was given an engagement ring two days ago and I haven't answered the guy yet *(Show ring on finger)* . . . so I wanted to do it this evening. *(To Adam)* Here goes. This is a beautiful stone and an amazing gesture on your part. By the time I'm through here, I promise that you'll have your answer . . .

INTRODUCTION

How far would you go for love? For art? What concessions would you make? What price would you be willing to pay? Such are the painful questions explored by Neil Labute in The Shape of Things -- A modern retelling of the fall of man.

EVELYN: I present to you this, my newest work. It is a human sculpture on which I've worked these past eighteen weeks, and of whom I'm very proud. The piece itself – him – is untitled. I first spotted my chosen base material . . . it's so funny not to use names! Sorry, but a lawyer actually told me I had to say that, 'base material' . . . on January 9, the fifth day of winter semester. I created a scenario that would allow for our seemingly random connection.

*****Scene*****

(EVELYN stands near a stretch of velvet rope. She has a can in one hand and stares up at an enormous human sculpture. ADAM steps across the barrier and approaches her)

ADAM: . . . you stepped over the line, miss? Ummmm, you stepped over . . .

EVELYN: I meant to step over . . .

ADAM: What? Yeah, I figured you did. I mean, the way you did it an all, kinda deliberate like. you're not supposed to do that.

EVELYN: I know. That's why I tried it . . . to see what would happen.

ADAM: I'm what happens, I guess. I have to walk over, like I've done, and ask you to take a step back.

EVELYN: And if someone doesn't, what then?

ADAM: Hell, I dunno . . . I'm off in, like, ten minutes, I'd probably just stand here, make sure you didn't touch anything. Hey, you're not gonna mess up my weekend with this, are you?

EVELYN: I wasn't planning on it, but . . . I'm not completely against it, either.

ADAM: See, if you get all crazy, then I gotta write up a report and stuff, I'm here till six, six-thirty easy, and I have a second job to get to. . . step back behind the line there . . . I'd appreciate it.

EVELYN: No. sorry, I can't. I'm building up my nerve, and if I go back over, I'll probably be a big wuss about it and take off . . .

ADAM: About what? The 'wuss 'part, I mean . . .

EVELYN: I was going to do something to the nude. Mess it up or . . . paint a big *(gestures)* on it, but whatever . . .

ADAM: *(beat)* . . . so, right over the leaves there, or just a free-floating number.

EVELYN: probably anatomically correct. I mean, if you're gonna do it, why not . . .

ADAM: . . . do it right? Absolutely.

*******Scene*******

EVELYN: The hair, the glasses, the excessive amount of weight offered a number of physical areas that made him unique and perfect for this project. A short list of alterations I've induced would include eating better and losing weight – some twenty-five pounds or more

*******Scene*******

ADAM: . . . . You amaze me.

EVELYN: I'm glad. *(beat)* and you amaze me, you do. Look at you!

ADAM: It's just a little jogging.

EVELYN: No, it's not. It's not just that . . . you're running, you're eating better. Are you still lifting?

ADAM: Yeah . . . I mean, I didn't today, but . . . .

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EVELYN: Do you like doing it?

ADAM: Honestly . . . No. It totally hate it! *(they laugh)*

EVELYN: So why would you . . . ?

ADAM: Because you suggested it. Which is kinda pathetic, but true . . .

EVELYN: You shouldn't do something you don't wanna do.

ADAM: Yeah, you should. Why not? If it's for some one . . . I mean, I'm doing it for you.

EVELYN: I gave you a couple ides and you're changing your entire life. I'm very proud of you.

(Adam freezes in scene and Evelyn steps out to resume her presentation)

EVELYN: . . .the purchase of contact lenses

*****Scene***** *Adam and his friend Jenny in the park*

JENNY: You are getting cuter by the day. What is that girl doing to you?

ADAM: Lots . . . she's amazing, really.

JENNY: What happened to your . . . are you wearing . . . Adam, are those contacts?

ADAM: Yeah, contacts.

JENNY: My god, this from the former 'tape around the nose thing-y' champion.

ADAM: That was only for a week, that one time!

JENNY: Still, you've gotta admit . . .

ADAM: I do, it's amazing. I feel better . . .

JENNY: Better? You're like, this totally hot guy now . . . *(beat)* I always thought you were handsome, anyway, but I didn't think you'd go in for the makeover thing.

ADAM: Me either. Who knew? *(Adam freezes in scene and Evelyn steps out to resume her presentation)*

EVELYN: A complete change in hairstyles and significant wardrobe alterations as well. He even tattooed his body for me, without asking . . . in a highly questionable place.

*****Scene*****

ADAM: I can show you something . . . just a little thing I had done. For you.

EVELYN: Wait, what . . . show me. *(he looks around and lowers his pants to show his backside)* "EAT" . . . lemme guess . . . you couldn't afford the "me."

ADAM: No, you goof! Your initials: Evelyn Ann Thompson. Like it?

EVELYN: I do. I like it. And I love the gesture . . .

ADAM: "Love" is a big word.

EVELYN: I know. That's why I used it. . . *(Adam freezes in scene readjusting his pants and Evelyn steps out to resume her presentation)* These are surface items, to be sure, but if I, in fact, tell you that I'm going through with it and marrying the guy, you'd probably all shake my hand and say, "Wow, how can I do that to my boyfriend?" But this, I'm afraid was not done out of love or caring or concern . . . this was a simple matter of can I instill "X" amount of change in this creature, using only manipulations as my palette knife? I coaxed, made suggestions, created the illusion of interest and desire, but never said, 'please do this.' Not once. As my subject became handsomer, firmer and more confident, his actions became more and more . . . questionable. He had work done to his face, cosmetic surgery at age 22, and insisted to those around him that he had merely fallen down.

*****Scene*****

ADAM: *(To audience as if speaking with friends, gesturing to his nose)* I hit it and, you know . . . I banged it pretty bad at home and so I had the doctor look at it. But he didn't . . . operate or anything. The bandage is from that . . . *(Adam freezes in scene touching his nose and Evelyn steps out to resume her presentation)*

EVELYN: He was willing to give friends up when asked, walk away from them without any further contact . . . and as stated earlier these corrections culminated in an offer of marriage to me, this coming from a confirmed, albeit young, bachelor.

*****Scene*****

(We enter the scene in the middle of an argument between Evelyn and Adam – the reason for the argument is unimportant, just the conclusion)

ADAM: So, tell me what to do and I'll do it. . . I just, I just don't wanna lose you.

EVELYN: You're sure . . . ?

ADAM: I am so sure. I love you . . .

EVELYN: Anything I say?

ADAM: Anything.

EVELYN: *(without emotion)* Give up [your] friends, both of them. No explanation. Don't see them or speak to them again, not ever. That's the proof to me about how you feel . . .

ADAM: Evelyn . . . that's . . .

EVELYN: Once should always be careful when asking to be put to a test. . . so what's it gonna be, Adam?

ADAM: . . . and if I don't . . . ?

EVELYN: These things end. I mean, in life, at least . . . Final answer? *(Adam stares at her for a long moment)*

ADAM: . . . I choose you. *(Adam freezes in scene after dropping to one knee as if to propose and Evelyn steps out to resume her presentation)*

EVELYN: He has then been utterly and totally refashioned as a person *(beat)* He's gotten more interesting, more desirable, more normal. In a word, better. He is a living, breathing example of our obsession with the surface of things, the shape of them. *(to ADAM – taking off the ring)* This was a startling and unexpected gesture, but obviously, I can't accept. *(To audience)* I have no feelings of remorse for my actions, the manufactured emotions . . . none of it. I have always stood by the single and simple conceit that I am an artist. Only that. Art must be created, whatever the cost. *(beat)* @ith that in mind, I present you with my untitled sculpture. Thank you. *(she hands Adam the ring, takes a short bow and steps out of the light.)*

*****Scene***** *At the reception after Evelyn's presentation*

ADAM: . . . not a big "modern art" crowd, I guess, huh?

EVELYN: Look . . .

ADAM: Please don't "Look," me now, okay, or I might not make it through this. . . *(beat)* Just refer to me as "it" or "untitled," it'll help me keep some perspective here. . . *(wanders over and pours some punch. Stuffs a few cookies in pocket. Shoves three in mouth and chews them down.)*. . . that's gonna shoot some piece of data all to s***, isn't it?

EVELYN: Doesn't matter now, do what you want. . . you're finished.

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ADAM: "You're finished." Wow. *(considers)* Most people just say, "Hey, sorry, can't marry you." And they say it in private. . .

EVELYN: . . . yeah, that might've been a bit too far.

ADAM: Oh shit, you are so beyond "far" that you're in danger of hitting Uranus.

EVELYN: *(Smiling)* See, you're still funny....

ADAM: Just stop, alright? I was never funny, or good-looking or clever. I was nothing until you started . . . I admit it. No-thing. But you know what? I was absolutely fine with that. . .

EVELYN: . . . listen, I know my work relied on not telling you what was going on, but I. . .

ADAM: Here we just call it lying. . .

EVELYN: I did lie to you, yes . . . Sorry.

ADAM: You're sorry? Well, that's good. . . I figured I was gonna have to really work to get that one out of you.

EVELYN: I'm not sorry. I mean, not for what I've done. I just feel bad that you're so upset. . . I just want to keep it as truthful as possible.

ADAM: *(laughing)* That'll be different. . .

EVELYN: . . . you're so angry. . . What'd I do wrong? *(beat)* Seriously, tell me. . .

ADAM: You don't see this as wrong?! You honestly have no concept here. . . Look, I'm not gonna stand here. . .

EVELYN: The exercising? Or was it the new clothes that really bugged you? Everything I did made you a more desirable person. People began to notice you. . . take interest in you.

ADAM: Well, lucky me.

EVELYN: *(beat)* Look, if you hadn't been here tonight, hadn't heard all this stuff. . . wouldn't you still be happy? Waiting at home for me, hoping this went well. . .

ADAM: That's not the point. . .

EVELYN: Yes, it is! It's the total point. All that stuff we did was real for you, therefore it was real. It wasn't for me, therefore it wasn't. It's all subjective, Everything.

ADAM: Not love. Not cruelty. Seriously? . . . Don't fool yourself and think that this is "art." 'kay? It's a sick joke, but it is not "art."

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EVELYN: Is that right?

ADAM: *(beat)* You know, when Picasso took a s***, he didn't call it a "sculpture." He knew the difference. That's what made him Picasso. You oughta at least realize there's a price to it all...you know? Somebody pays for your two minutes on CNN. Someone always pays for people like you. And if you don't get that, then you're about two inches away from using babies to make lamp shades and calling it "furniture." *(beat)* Tell me, though. Was any of it true? Not the things we did, or the kind words or whatever. . . but any of it?

EVELYN: . . . No. Not really. Sorry.

ADAM: *(Sarcastic)* Don't be. Hey, it's. . . Art.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Neil Labute
ISBN: 978-0571212460
Publisher: Faber and Faber, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): Nov 2001

AWARD HISTORY

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